

Suicide is one of the leading causes of death in the United States. Suicide risk is associated with a variety of factors. Personal factors include childhood abuse, certain personality traits (eg, impulsiveness, aggression), and history of mental illness. Over 90% of people who attempt suicide meet diagnostic criteria for at least one psychological disorder, and suicide risk increases as the number of co-occurring disorders increases. Diagnosis severity also matters: studies suggest that individuals are at greatest risk of attempting suicide while inpatient at or newly discharged from a psychiatric hospital.

Social factors also play a role in suicide. Sociologist Émile Durkheim argued that embeddedness in society is a key feature in determining the likelihood of an individual committing suicide. Specifically, the more people that depend on an individual financially, emotionally, or physically, the less likely that individual is to commit suicide. Studies suggest that suicide is also linked to religious affiliation and income level. Religious groups that place more value on community events, church attendance, and collective solidarity tend to have lower rates of suicide among members, whereas more affluent individuals are more likely to commit suicide.

Economic trends have also been linked to suicide. One study retrospectively analyzed the relationship between the U.S. economy and suicide rates. It found that the overall suicide rate tends to rise during economic recessions and drop during economic expansions (Figure 1).

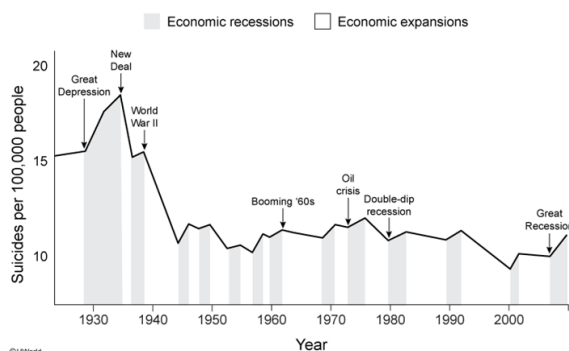


Figure 1 U.S. suicide rates compared to economic trends

Further analysis of suicide data suggests that for every individual who successfully commits suicide, approximately 25 individuals are unsuccessful in such attempts, costing the United States billions of dollars annually in both lost wages and treatment expense. Although white, middle-aged men are the most likely cohort to successfully commit suicide, women attempt suicide three times more often than men.

Durkheim is most often associated with which sociological theory?

- ✓ ☒ A. Structural functionalism [57%]
- ☐ B. Conflict theory [4%]
- ☐ C. Social constructionism [22%]
- ☐ D. Symbolic interactionism [15%]

Correct

57% answered correctly

Explanation:

Major theoretical approaches to sociology			
Theory	Description	Perspective	Theorists
Functionalism	- Society = an organism - Each part of society works to maintain dynamic equilibrium (homeostasis)	Macro	Émile Durkheim, Talcott Parsons
Conflict	- Society = struggle for limited resources - Inequality based on social class	Macro	Karl Marx, Max Weber
Social constructionism	- Social actors define what is real - Knowledge about world based on interactions	Macro or micro	(Not critical for exam)
Symbolic interactionism	- Meaning & value attached to symbols - Individual interactions based on these symbols	Micro	Charles Cooley, George Herbert Mead
Rational choice/social exchange	Individual behaviors & interactions attempt to maximize personal gain & minimize personal cost	Micro	(Not critical for exam)
Feminist	Examines gender inequality in society	Macro or micro	(Not critical for exam)

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The major theoretical approaches in sociology view society from either a macro-level or micro-level perspective. Theories with a **macro-level** perspective look at how larger social structures (eg, education and health care systems) function in society and impact the lives of those living in that society. Theories with a **micro-level** perspective look at how interactions between individuals (eg, teacher and student, doctor and patient) shape society.

Structural functionalism is a macro-level sociological perspective that compares society to a biological organism. This theory proposes that, like the various organ systems attempting to maintain homeostasis in an organism, all aspects of society work together to maintain **dynamic equilibrium** (societal balance). For example, the health care system functions to keep people optimally healthy so that they can work and contribute to society, and the education system functions to teach and train people who will in turn contribute to society. **Émile Durkheim** is the theorist most often associated with structural functionalism.

(Choice B) Karl Marx and Max Weber are most often associated with conflict theory, a macro-level sociological perspective which argues that conflict between social classes in society is inevitable.

(Choice C) Social constructionism is either a micro- or macro-level perspective that argues that members of a given society define what constitutes reality. For instance, race is a social construct based arbitrarily on skin color.

(Choice D) Charles Cooley and George Herbert Mead are most often associated with symbolic interactionism, which is a micro-level perspective that argues we attach meaning to symbols in society, and that interpersonal interaction is based on those symbols and meanings.

Educational objective:

In sociology, macro-level theories look at how social structures impact society, whereas micro-level theories look at how individual interactions shape society. Émile Durkheim is

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most often associated with structural functionalism, a macro-level theory that compares society to an organism in which each component of society attempts to maintain homeostasis (dynamic equilibrium).

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:

Behavioral Sciences

QID:400456

System:

Identity and Social Interaction

Suicide is one of the leading causes of death in the United States. Suicide risk is associated with a variety of factors. Personal factors include childhood abuse, certain personality traits (eg, impulsiveness, aggression), and history of mental illness. Over 90% of people who attempt suicide meet diagnostic criteria for at least one psychological disorder, and suicide risk increases as the number of co-occurring disorders increases. Diagnosis severity also matters: studies suggest that individuals are at greatest risk of attempting suicide while inpatient at or newly discharged from a psychiatric hospital.

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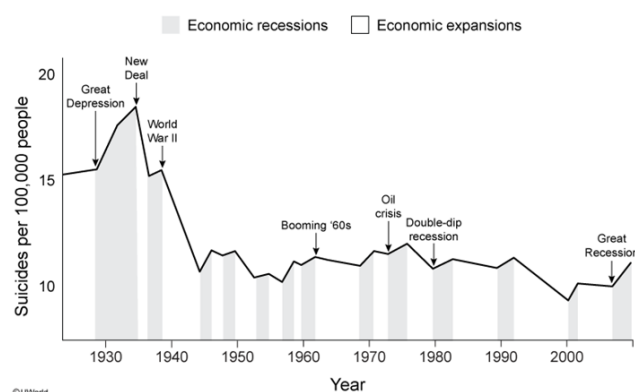


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"Suicide clusters" are greater-than-average rates of suicide occurring within a short time frame. After a well-publicized initial suicide, suicide rates tend to rise, particularly among teenagers and young adults. This phenomenon can also be described as:

- ☐ A. groupthink. [3%]
- ☐ B. the mere exposure effect. [39%]
- ☐ C. mass hysteria. [18%]
- ✓ ☒ D. imitation of a reference group. [37%]

Correct

37% answered correctly

Explanation:

A **reference group** is a **comparison group**. Individuals compare their beliefs and behaviors to those of reference group members and often model the beliefs and behaviors of the reference group. For example, after a well-publicized suicide, others who have already contemplated taking their life may consider modeling the behavior of the individual who committed suicide, notwithstanding that suicide occurs for multiple, complex reasons.

Therefore, "suicide clusters" (higher-than-average rates of suicide occurring within a short time frame) may occur as a result of *imitation of a reference group* (ie, individuals already contemplating suicide modeling the behavior of those who have recently committed suicide).

(Choice A) Groupthink occurs when groups of individuals engage in dysfunctional, dangerous, or nonsensical behavior because a desire for group cohesion outweighs critical decision-making. Groupthink explains the conscious decision-making practices that occur within a defined group, so it does not explain why suicide clusters happen.

(Choice B) The mere exposure effect (or familiarity effect) argues that just the act of being exposed to something increases an individual's affinity for it. For example, the more someone hears a song, the more they will *like* the song. The mere exposure effect explains why people like certain things, but it cannot explain complex behavior like suicide.

(Choice C) Mass hysteria (or group hysteria) occurs when fear and rumor spur similar behavior among many group members. Examples of mass hysteria

generally include physical symptoms (eg, twitching, laughing) that have no apparent cause and spread within an isolated community. No examples are found of suicide caused by mass hysteria.

Educational objective:

Reference groups are groups to which individuals compare themselves. Individuals are more likely to adjust their attitudes and behaviors to align with those of a reference group.

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Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400457

System:
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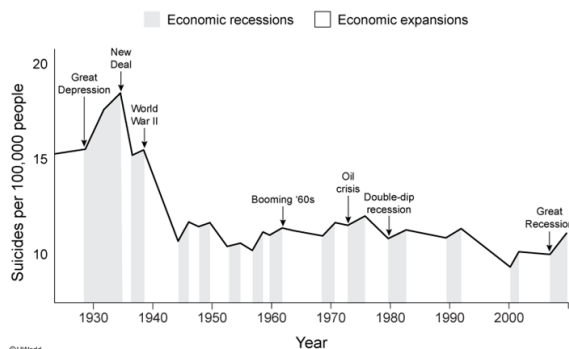


Figure 1 U.S. suicide rates compared to economic trends

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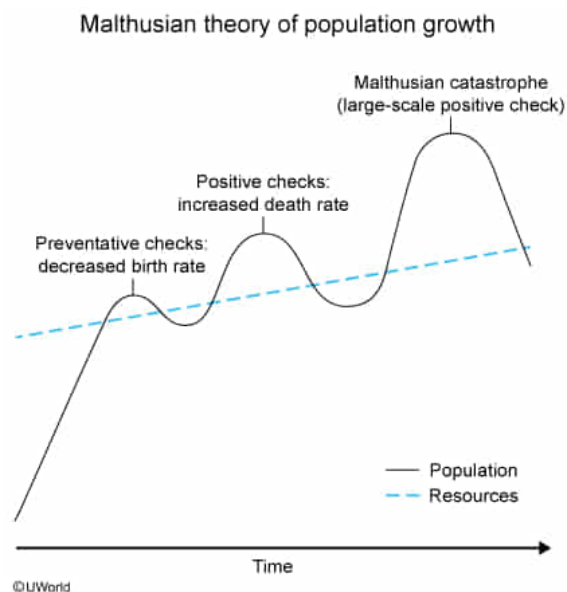
How would a proponent of Malthusian theory most likely interpret the data in Figure 1?

- ☐ A. Increased suicide rates provide evidence for a Malthusian catastrophe. [14%]
- ☐ B. The decline in suicide rates during World War II supports Malthusian theory. [14%]
- ☒ C. The Great Depression would be considered a positive check. [39%]
- ☐ D. Increased suicide rates during recessions are negative checks. [31%]

Correct

39% answered correctly

Explanation:



The **Malthusian theory of population growth** suggests that the human population increases exponentially while resources increase at a slower rate. According to this theory, the population growth rate can be slowed by preventative checks and positive checks.

Preventative checks are those that decrease the birth rate (and are typically voluntary, such as waiting to marry and having fewer children). **Positive checks** increase the death rate, slowing population growth by shortening the average life span. Positive checks can be small-scale (eg, increased death rate due to a flu virus) or large-scale (eg, an epidemic that wipes out half the population). Large-scale positive checks, called **Malthusian catastrophes** (eg, widespread famine, disease epidemics, large-scale wars), dramatically reduce the population to a level that the available resources can easily sustain, by slowing or stopping population growth entirely.

(Choice A) Increases in suicide rates, even up to the highest rates in Figure 1 (15-20 suicides per 100,000 people), will not have a large enough impact on the population to be considered a Malthusian catastrophe.

(Choice B) According to Malthusian theory, the increased death rate (not the decreased suicide rate) during World War II would be considered a positive check, supporting the theory.

(Choice D) A negative check does not exist in Malthusian theory, only positive checks and preventative checks.

Educational objective:

The Malthusian theory of population growth asserts that when the population grows faster than the resources necessary to sustain that population, preventative checks (reducing the birthrate) or positive checks (increasing the death rate) can slow down growth. A

Malthusian catastrophe is a large-scale positive check that slows or stops population growth.

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Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400458

System:
Identity and Social Interaction

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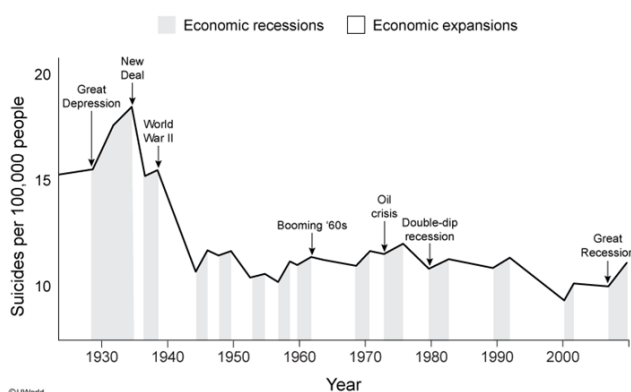


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Sociologists often consider suicide a deviant behavior because suicide:

- ☐ A. is relatively uncommon compared to other ways of dying. [4%]
- ☐ B. is a folkway in American culture. [3%]
- ☐ C. incurs formal, but not informal, sanctions. [1%]
- ✔ ☒ D. violates a major normative social script. [90%]

Correct

89% answered correctly

Explanation:

Type of norm	Degree of deviance	Social repercussions
Folkways (eg, wearing clothes backward)	Least deviant	Minor punishments (eg, staring)
Mores (eg, wearing no clothes in public)	More deviant	More serious punishment (eg, arrest)
Taboos (eg, incest, suicide)	Most deviant	Most serious punishment (eg, incarceration)

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Deviance is any behavior that violates culturally established norms. Deviant behavior can be viewed as simply odd or off-putting (eg, nose-picking in public) or can be viewed as egregious or criminal (eg, shooting someone). Deviant behavior considered morally reprehensible by society is known as a **taboo**. Suicide violates the major social script of protecting ourselves and trying to avoid pain, and is considered taboo in most societies.

Norms that dictate how to behave (also known as normative social scripts) exist in every culture and serve to disseminate information about appropriate conduct in a variety of situations. Folkways are less formal social norms whereas mores are more formal social norms. A violation of folkways (eg, walking outside with all your clothes on backward) is unlikely to draw more than a few raised eyebrows, but violation of mores (eg, walking outside naked) is likely to result in more formal punishment.

(Choice A) Deviant behavior is not defined by how uncommon it is.

(Choice B) Folkways are informal normative behaviors, practices, and traditions in society.

(Choice C) Both formal and informal sanctions exist for attempting suicide. Formal sanctions are those codified by law (eg, involuntary confinement for a suicide attempt), and informal sanctions are behaviors that occur at the individual level (eg, social shunning, disapproval).

Educational objective:

Deviance is the violation of culturally sanctioned normative behavior. Deviant behavior that is morally reprehensible is considered a taboo.

Time spent:0 sec**Subject:**
Behavioral Sciences**QID:**400459**System:**
Identity and Social Interaction